



Nextdoor goes to Germany

Nextdoor, the free private social networking app for neighbourhoods enters Germany after its success in the US and UK <http://dgit.in/NextGerm>



Power consuming currency

The Ethereum network is estimated to be using as much as 42 Terawatt-hours, slightly more than the country of Cyprus <http://dgit.in/ithuRum>

THE DIGIT COMMUNITY IS FILLED WITH BRIGHT IDEAS and we find the best among the best every month to bring them to you in this section.

WannaCry: Bringing doom to Windows



Does WannaCry's proliferation suggest we should move to Linux?

Ankit Yadav | feedback@dgit.in

Amongst the endless reactions on social media to the unprecedented WannaCry ransomware attack, one peculiar notion popped up again and again. Is this a wake up call to move to Linux? Is a Linux-based operating system completely immune to ransomware attacks? Are Linux-based distros any better than Windows operating systems as far as cyber-security is concerned? There are several aspects to these queries waiting to be addressed.

Firstly, it should be understood that Linux has a very miniscule market share in operating systems. If we discount the market share of Google's Android, as of April 2017, Linux approximately has a 0.77% market share. Any cyber-criminal will always aim to target as many users as possible, and that's why they attack the player holding the largest market share – Microsoft Windows. The WannaCry ransomware won't affect Linux-powered machines because it was not made for Linux-based machines. Moreover, it's not as if there have been no ransomware attacks on Linux. In November 2015, a ransomware named Linux.Encoder.1 made headlines as it affected dozens of Linux users.

Earlier, it was believed that Windows XP machines were being targeted. This implied that Windows XP and other unsupported versions of Windows were naturally vulnerable to the ransomware. Costin Raiu, director of Global Research and Analysis Team at Kaspersky Lab,

apparently brought a new twist to the story claiming that about 98 percent of computers infected were running Windows 7, and the effect on Windows XP was almost insignificant.

WINDOWS UPDATES AND OTHER ASPECTS

Microsoft keeps frequently releasing patches for security and other system related improvements for supported operating systems. Most of the annoying updates that you receive now and then serve a crucial purpose of overcoming critical (sometimes fatal) security flaws. Windows 7 still runs approximately half of the world's desktops. Moreover, its extended support ends on January 14, 2020, meaning the operating system must have received a security patch against the ransomware in March itself. So, how did it all happen? Well, it's obvious. People did not update their devices.

Microsoft's software is quite famous for being easily pirated and capable of running almost everything a genuine copy would have allowed. However, it won't receive Microsoft's official updates, including its security patches.

Windows updates are known to be time-consuming, and unreliable. They used to be optional earlier but Windows 10 onwards they have been made compulsory. Although it's a good security measure, the machines are rendered useless while updating since the updates won't install in the background. Recently, there has been issues with software compatibility as well. More and more programs written for previous versions are failing to run on the latest builds of Windows 10. Kaspersky Lab even filed a complaint with Russian Federal Antimonopoly Service, contending that Microsoft's anti-competitive practices have made it nearly impossible for developers to keep their products compatible with Windows 10. There have indeed been cases where programs that managed to run on an initial build of Windows 10 have failed to run on an updated build.

SO, IS LINUX THE ANSWER?

It has been claimed for a long time that Linux is innately more secure than Windows. Although there is some truth to the claim, due to Linux's origin in Unix, and the way it handles administra-